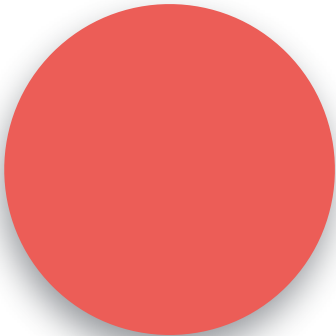
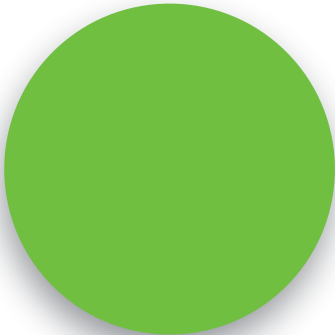
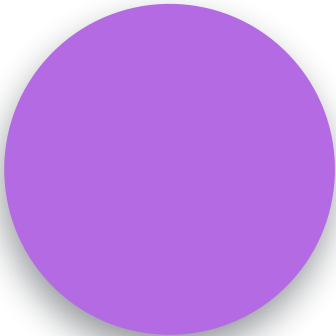












What is justice?

an individual society → which for our purposes we can take to be a

mean for an international system of distinct societies to be just.

ask what it means for a person to be just. We can also ask what it

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can

nation — to be just.

This question is sometimes called the question of distributive

a society at a time.

justice, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within

What goods are we talking about?

One category is what we might call material goods. These include

things like food and property and income.

rights (such as the right to vote) and liberties (such as the

one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include political

freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job

This is enough to describe a society which most of us would agree

to be unjust.



enslaved the members of group B, depriving them by force of their

property, and gives members of group B only the are minimized

the property of subgroup B . Group A consolidates its power, and

At some initial time t , the members of a society are living in a state of

relative quality. But at later time $t+1$, some sub-group A takes all of

for survival. Members of group B are only permitted to serve group A

freedom to pursue an education). By time $t+2$, group A owns all the

political rights and liberties (such as freedom of association and the

in the ways that members of group A direct.

It is universal that, at $t+2$, this is an unjust society.

answers to this question.

The interesting question is: why is this? What would have to be different

for this to be a just society? Different theories of justice provide different

Our first theory of justice provides a very straightforward answer to this

inequality. On this view, a just society is one in which goods are

distributed equally. This view is egalitarianism.

question. On this view, what is unjust about our imagined society is its

answer would be that everyone gets exactly the same goods. Everyone

What would it mean for goods to be distributed equally? A simple

get the same food, just the same kind of residence, etc.

But if you think about it, this wouldn't be an ideal set-up. Suppose that

more spinach and less broccoli? And yet this would seem to be unjust on

love and hate spin each, and you are the reverse. Wouldn't it be

better for me to get more brocoli and less spinach, and for you to get

our simplest egalitarian view.

could then use this money on broccoli, and you could use it on spinach.

The fact that we made different choices would not make the distribution

the same goods. Instead, perhaps we each should get exactly the same

an equal distribution of goods need not mean that we each get exactly

of goods unequal.

The natural response to this on behalf of the egalitarian is to say that

we would each get the same amount of money and the same income.

opportunity to buy goods. In a society like ours, this would mean that

A second problem for the egalitarian is the problem of how to handle

inequalities that emerge over time.

Even if we specify that you and I get the same income at every period in

and yours was not.

clever with yours, so that after 20 years you have accumulated large

our lives, we might still end up with very unequal distribution of goods.

amount of resources. Or maybe my house was destroyed by a tornado,

might be very wasteful with my resources where a might be very

egalitarian. Should we simply permit this kind of inequality, or should

unequal distribution of resources. This leads to a dilemma for the

It's like, at the end of this 20 year period, we might have a very

there a non-trivial distribution of resources to restore equality?

to rule out as unjust certain activities (like using one's resources wisely

be unjust.

goods. But when we look at how this might work, we find that it seems

idea that a just society would be one with an equal distribution of

to save up goods for one's self and one's children) which do not seem to

We seem to be at an impasse. The egalitarians start with the plausible

ignoring the way in which pain is distributed — which seems to

equality and instead just focused on the total happiness in a society. But

push back in the direction of egalitarianism.

We then turned to utilitarianism, which ignores considerations of

then we have a plausible argument that utilitarianism goes wrong in

It is tempting to say that we need 'something in the middle.' Maybe so.

But even if so, what principled reasons could we have for deciding where?

children will have much greater resourcth an mine from the start.

The problem is exacerbated if we think about families. Suppose that you

vest.

are clever with your resources and want to pass them along to your



children, whereas I give my children nothing. Then it looks like you

Obviously over a number of generations, the difference might become

looks unjust, from egalitarian perspective.

Here the same kind of dilemma arises. Do we simply permit the vast

different resources, even from the beginning of one's life? That

see this as an unacceptable restriction on one's freedom.

allowing parents to pass along their values to their children? Many

Or do we instead consistently redistribute wealth, for example by not

The egalitarian seemed forced to either permit it in a

the purpose of the view to avoid or adopt every strong redistributive

principles which restrict freedom in the use of one's resources.